INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #48 · GRIEF AND LOSS

“Moving on means forgetting them.”

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Where it often comes from

Many grieving people fear that feeling better is a betrayal. If we laugh, enjoy a meal, or begin to plan ahead, it can feel like leaving the person behind. Some hold on to pain because it feels like the last connection.

What Scripture teaches

Solomon writes, “A time to weep and a time to laugh, a time to mourn and a time to dance.” Paul says, “We do not want you to be uninformed about those who sleep in death, so that you will not grieve like the rest, who are without hope.” The psalmist says that God keeps our tears in His bottle. Jesus wept, and so can we. David said of his child, “I will go to him, but he will not return to me,” and then he rose and went on living. Moving forward is not forgetting. We carry the people we love with us, and their memory can become a source of gratitude as well as pain.

> *“A time to weep and a time to laugh, a time to mourn and a time to dance”* (Ecclesiastes 3:4).

Also see

> “Brothers, we do not want you to be uninformed about those who sleep in death, so that you will not grieve like the rest, who are without hope” (1 Thessalonians 4:13).

> “You have taken account of my wanderings. Put my tears in Your bottle— are they not in Your book?” (Psalm 56:8).

> “Jesus wept” (John 11:35).

> “But now that he is dead, why should I fast? Can I bring him back again? I will go to him, but he will not return to me” (2 Samuel 12:23).

Common self-statements

- If I smile, I am betraying them.
- If I stop hurting, it means I did not love them.
- I must keep suffering to honor them.
- I do not deserve to be happy.
- Moving on is disloyal.
- I will forget their voice and face.

Common logical errors

- Emotional reasoning: Feeling guilty about joy and concluding that it is wrong.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must either grieve forever or forget.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should keep suffering.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining that healing means losing them.

Challenging questions

- What would honoring them look like besides suffering?
- What would they want for me?

- What do I fear I will lose if I feel better?
- What can I do to keep their memory alive?
- How did people in Scripture mourn and go on?
- What small step toward living again could I take?

Truth summary

> Moving forward does not mean forgetting. I can carry my loved one's memory with me and still laugh, plan, and live. Joy is not a betrayal, and honoring them can include living well.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grief
- Sorrow
- Death/Dying
- Joy
- Heaven

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Grief
- Depression

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ's resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Forever — Kari Jobe
Christ's resurrection grounds hope in His victory over sin and death.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Moving on means forgetting them"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Moving on means forgetting them." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What would honor them?
- ☐ What would they want for me?
- ☐ What do I fear losing?
- ☐ How can I keep their memory?
- ☐ What small joy can I allow?
- ☐ Who can I share stories with?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ There is a time to mourn and a time to dance.
- ☐ Joy is not disloyalty.
- ☐ I can remember and live.
- ☐ God keeps my tears.
- ☐ I grieve with hope.
- ☐ Their love lives on in me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Ecclesiastes 3:4
  "A time to weep and a time to laugh, a time to mourn and a time to dance."
- ☐ 1 Thessalonians 4:13
  "Brothers, we do not want you to be uninformed about those who sleep in death, so that you will not grieve like the rest, who are without hope."
- ☐ Psalm 56:8
  "You have taken account of my wanderings. Put my tears in Your bottle— are they not in Your book?"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Remembering and living: Each week, note one way you remembered them and one way you lived fully.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Ecclesiastes 3:4 becomes: "Sarah can write: "There is a time to mourn and a time to dance, and I can remember them while I live.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Grief" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Create a memory ritual. Make a photo book, light a candle, or visit a place.
- [ ] Ask what they would want. Write what you think they would say about your life now.
- [ ] Allow a good moment. Let yourself enjoy something small without guilt.
- [ ] Share their stories. Tell others about them.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Moving on means forgetting them": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Remembering and living
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Moving on means forgetting them.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I fear letting go. Help me carry the love I have for them, honor their memory, and allow joy to return without guilt. Thank You for the gift of their life. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.